INDIA'S TRYST WITH 'ALIENS'

- In November 2023, flight operations at Imphal airport were suspended for three hours and two fighter jets scrambled after a white unidentified object was spotted near the ATC tower. The incident remains unexplained to this day
- But UFO lore is most commonly linked to remote Himalayan regions, particularly Kongka Pass along the LAC in Ladakh, where visibility can stretch across several kilometres
- In 2012-13, Indian army lookouts stationed near Pangong Tso lake reported a bright object moving vertically in the eastern sky. It turned out to be the planet Jupiter, according to an astronomer involved in the investigation
- Long before Hollywood popularised friendly aliens, Satyajit Ray wrote *The Alien*, an unmade sci-fi screenplay developed nearly 15 years before Steven Spielberg's *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial* (1982)
- Ray's script was based on his short story *Bankubabur Bandhu*, about an alien landing in rural Bengal. Indian popular culture has repeatedly revisited the theme in films such as *Koi... Mil Gaya* (2003) and *PK* (2014)

Jayant Murthy, a Bengaluru-based astrophysicist, believes **all UAP sightings ultimately have "good explanations"**, ranging from natural phenomena to military aircraft unfamiliar to observers

search for technological signatures of extraterrestrial life. Loeb, however, believes the disclosures still serve an important purpose by bringing discussions around UAP into mainstream scientific discourse. "Interesting details regarding the videos are unfortunately redacted, and all images could be explained as either reflections in the camera optics or human-made objects," he adds.

The flashes reported by Buzz Aldrin, for instance, could plausibly have been caused by cosmic rays or micrometeoroids, Loeb suggests. Lacking an atmosphere or a magnetosphere, the Moon's surface is exposed to a cosmic-ray flux 200 times larger than that on the Earth's surface, he explains. In fact, astronauts aboard NASA's recent Artemis 2 mission—the first human lunar mission since Apollo 17—also observed "impact flashes", brief flickers caused by meteoroids striking the lunar surface. Earlier this year, NASA launched a citizen science initiative called 'Impact Flash!', encouraging amateur astronomers to help monitor such events using telescopes and cameras.

NASA has expanded its engagement with UAP research since a 2023 recommendation by an external study panel, partly aimed at reducing the stigma associated with reporting such incidents. Elsewhere, governments have pursued similar efforts. France's space agency CNES, for instance, has operated a dedicated unit known as GEIPAN—the Group for Study and Information on Unidentified Aerospace Phenomena—since the late 1970s to analyse reports within French territory.

GEIPAN is careful to state that it does not investigate extraterrestrial life or paranormal phenomena. Statistics published on its website show that, of the 3,351 UAP cases examined so far, 27.8 per cent were categorised as "perfectly identified" phenomena, 38.8 per cent as "probably identified", while 30.3 per cent remained "unidentified owing to lack of data". Only 3.1 per cent were "unidentified after investigation"—suggesting that most sightings turn out to have conventional explanations.

What Lies Ahead

Loeb argues that the mystery surrounding UAPs can only be resolved through "high-quality evidence". "Knowing the distance, velocity and acceleration of these objects would address the question of whether any of them lies outside the performance envelope of human-made technologies," he says. His Galileo Project seeks to triangulate multiple objects in the sky and use artificial intelligence to ascertain their nature—a complementary approach to the decades-old Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI) programme, which focuses on detecting electromagnetic signals from space.

More declassified records are expected in the months ahead. "This is an unprecedented, historic undertaking that requires coordination between dozens of agencies and the review of tens of millions of records, many existing only on paper, spanning many decades," a US government statement said, adding that its Department of War will continue to release new tranches every few weeks as material is discovered and cleared for disclosure. "The best has yet to come," reckons Loeb, arguing that higher-quality material will take longer to clear layers of bureaucratic vetting before release. The mystery, for now, continues. ■